Adversarial Contingency Auctions: Strategic Multi-Robot Task Allocation under Inconsistent Beliefs and Stochastic Infrastructure Collapse

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***Abstract*—This paper introduces the Adversarial Contingency Auctions (ACA) framework, a decentralized multi-agent task allocation architecture for heterogeneous robot fleets operating in adversarial and communication-constrained environments. Existing multi-robot systems typically address stochastic routing uncertainty, inconsistent beliefs, or distributed auctions independently. However, real-world deployments such as disaster-response logistics, urban autonomy under GPS spoofing, and contested humanitarian operations simultaneously exhibit strategic infrastructure collapse, partial observability, belief divergence, and restricted communication budgets.**

To address this gap, ACA integrates four key capabilities into a unified framework: (1) decentralized Bayesian adversary inference, (2) theory-of-mind teammate belief estimation, (3) information-theoretic auction penalties using Kullback-Leibler divergence, and (4) contingency-aware A* trajectory branching under adversarial blockage risk.

Robots maintain inconsistent local world models due to limited sensing and communication constraints while dynamically allocating tasks using decentralized auctions. To mitigate coordination failures during network collapse, agents regularize bids using inferred teammate belief distributions, enabling graceful degradation even after synchronization failure. The framework is implemented as a discrete-event simulation architecture using heterogeneous robot fleets operating on dynamically mutated graphs with adversarial edge blockages.

Experimental simulation studies demonstrate that ACA reduces allocation conflicts and improves routing robustness under adversarial communication degradation compared to baseline decentralized auction methods.

ACA provides a tractable systems realization of strategic decentralized planning under adversarial uncertainty and serves as a scalable foundation for resilient multi-robot coordination in contested environments.

***Index Terms*—Multi-Robot Systems, Task Allocation, Decentralized Auctions, Belief Space Planning, Adversarial Robotics, Contingency Planning, Communication Constraints, Theory of Mind, Autonomous Systems**

I. Introduction

Autonomous multi-robot systems are increasingly deployed in environments where classical coordination assumptions fail. Disaster-response operations after earthquakes and floods, humanitarian logistics in contested territories, urban delivery networks under GPS spoofing, and military reconnaissance missions all exhibit simultaneous uncertainty in communication, environment dynamics, and adversarial behavior.

Traditional task allocation methods such as Consensus-Based Bundle Algorithms (CBBA) and Sequential Single-Item (SSI) auctions assume reliable communication and relatively stable environmental topology. In contrast, real-world deployments often experience:

- Intermittent or jammed communication channels,
- Strategically evolving environmental blockages,
- Inconsistent local beliefs across agents,
- Dynamically arriving tasks,
- Heterogeneous fleets with differing sensing and mobility capabilities.

Recent work has addressed these challenges in isolation. Contingency games model uncertainty over future agent intent. Stochastic blockage task allocation considers environmental uncertainty. Communication-aware belief-space planning studies inconsistent local observations. Distributed auctions scale to large robot populations. However, no unified framework jointly models adversarial environmental mutation, decentralized inconsistent beliefs, and auction-based task allocation under communication collapse.

To address this limitation, we propose the **Adversarial Contingency Auctions (ACA)** framework. ACA integrates decentralized Bayesian adversary inference, theory-of-mind teammate belief prediction, information-theoretic bidding penalties, and contingency-aware trajectory planning into a unified decentralized coordination architecture.

The primary contributions of this work are:

1) A decentralized adversarial task allocation framework under inconsistent beliefs.
2) A KL-divergence regularized auction mechanism that stabilizes allocations under communication collapse.
3) A contingency-aware A* trajectory planner for routing under strategic blockages.

4) A scalable simulation architecture for heterogeneous robot fleets operating on dynamically mutated graphs.
5) Preliminary simulation-based evaluation demonstrating improved coordination robustness under adversarial uncertainty.

II. Related Work

Consensus-Based Bundle Algorithms (CBBA) remain among the most widely studied decentralized task allocation methods for multi-agent coordination. Choi et al. [1] demonstrated scalable consensus-based auctions under distributed communication assumptions.

Research in decentralized coordination under communication restrictions has explored auction degradation and local consensus failures [2]. However, these approaches generally assume static environments and synchronized beliefs.

Belief-space planning under inconsistent observations has recently emerged as a significant direction in cooperative robotics. Kundu et al. proposed communication-aware cooperative belief-space planning with inconsistent beliefs and action-consistency constraints.

Stochastic routing and task assignment under uncertain environmental conditions were explored by Wilde and Alonso-Mora, who introduced stochastic blockage-aware task allocation for robot fleets.

Adversarial path planning and active sensing in contested environments have also been studied extensively [3]. However, existing approaches generally separate routing, task allocation, and belief reasoning into independent optimization layers.

Our work differs by integrating:

- adversarial graph mutation,
- decentralized inconsistent beliefs,
- communication-constrained auctions,
- contingency trajectory planning,
- theory-of-mind belief estimation,
- and information-theoretic bid regularization

within a unified systems architecture.

III. Problem Formulation

A. Graph Environment

Let

$$G = (V, E)$$

represent a connected undirected graph where:

- V is the set of task locations,
- E is the set of traversable edges.

Each edge

$$e = (u, v) \in E$$

possesses:

- traversal weight $w_e \in \mathbb{R}^+$,
- blockage state $X_e \in \{0, 1\}$,

where $X_e = 1$ denotes a blocked edge.

B. Adversary Model

A strategic adversary possesses hidden type

$$\theta \in \{\theta_1, \theta_2\}$$

where:

- θ_1: stochastic blocker,
- θ_2: reactive jammer.

For risky edges

$$E_{risk} \subset E$$

the blockage probabilities are:

1) Stochastic Blocker:

$$P(X_e = 1 \mid \theta_1) = P_{base}$$

2) Reactive Jammer:

$$P(X_e = 1 \mid \theta_2) = \min(1.0, P_{base} + \alpha N_e)$$

where:

- N_e is the robot density near edge e,
- α is the adversarial influence coefficient.

C. Robot Fleet

A fleet of R heterogeneous robots is deployed. Each robot r contains:

$$r = (ID_r, l_r, C_r, \beta_r, d_r, s_r, \kappa_r)$$

where:

- l_r: current node,
- C_r: battery capacity,
- β_r: traversal energy factor,
- d_r: idle energy drain,
- s_r: sensing radius,
- κ_r: communication budget.

Each robot maintains a private local belief graph:

$$G_r = (V, E_r)$$

with edge states:

$$X_e^{(r)} \in \{0, 1, \text{Uncertain}\}$$

due to partial observability.

D. Belief Representation

Each robot maintains a private belief distribution:

$$B_r = [P_r(\theta_1), P_r(\theta_2)]$$

subject to:

$$P_r(\theta_1) + P_r(\theta_2) = 1$$

Initial priors are uniform:

$$B_r = [0.5, 0.5]$$

IV. Bayesian Belief Update

Upon observing risky edge states, robots update adversary beliefs using Bayes' Rule:

$$P_r(\theta_j \mid X_e) = \frac{P_r(X_e \mid \theta_j)P_r(\theta_j)}{\sum_{k=1}^{2} P_r(X_e \mid \theta_k)P_r(\theta_k)} \tag{1}$$

Likelihoods are evaluated differently under each adversary type.

For the stochastic blocker:

$$P_r(X_e = 1 \mid \theta_1) = P_{base}$$

For the reactive jammer:

$$P_r(X_e = 1 \mid \theta_2) = \min(1.0, P_{base} + \alpha \hat{N}_e^{(r)})$$

where:

$$\hat{N}_e^{(r)}$$

is the robot's local estimate of nearby robot density.

V. Theory-of-Mind Belief Prediction

To predict teammate beliefs, robot r maintains estimated peer distributions:

$$\hat{B}_p^{(r)} = [\hat{P}_p^{(r)}(\theta_1), \hat{P}_p^{(r)}(\theta_2)]$$

Robot r simulates what robot p should believe using:

- last known position,
- sensing range,
- observed edge states.

This enables decentralized belief estimation without transmitting full belief vectors.

VI. Contingency-Aware Planning

ACA employs contingency-aware A* search.

When a planned trajectory intersects risky edge:

$$e_{risk} = (u, v)$$

the planner branches into two possible trajectories.

A. Optimistic Branch

Assuming the edge remains traversable:

$$Cost_A = Cost(Start \to u) + w_{(u,v)} + Cost(v \to Goal)$$

B. Contingency Branch

Assuming the edge becomes blocked:

$$Cost_B = Cost(Start \to u) + Cost_{detour}$$

The expected trajectory cost becomes:

$$E_r[Cost] = P_r(\theta_1)Cost_A + P_r(\theta_2)Cost_B \tag{2}$$

VII. KL-Regularized Auctions

Tasks are allocated using Sequential Single-Item (SSI) auctions.

The bid submitted by robot r for task t is:

$$Bid_r(t) = E_r[Cost] + \lambda D_{KL}(B_r||Q^{(r)}) \tag{3}$$

where:

- $E_r[Cost]$: contingency trajectory expectation,
- λ: regularization coefficient,
- $Q^{(r)}$: inferred teammate belief distribution.

The teammate belief approximation is:

$$Q^{(r)}(\theta_j) = \frac{1}{|N|} \sum_{p \in N} \hat{P}_p^{(r)}(\theta_j)$$

The KL-divergence penalty is:

$$D_{KL}(B_r||Q^{(r)}) = \sum_{j=1}^{2} P_r(\theta_j) \ln\left(\frac{P_r(\theta_j)}{Q^{(r)}(\theta_j)}\right) \tag{4}$$

This regularization discourages highly divergent decentralized allocations during communication collapse.

VIII. Communication-Constrained Consensus

Each auction round incurs communication overhead proportional to robot population:

$$Comm = R \cdot c$$

where c is message exchange cost.

If cumulative communication exceeds budget:

$$Comm > \kappa$$

then:

1) communication synchronization halts,
2) robots continue independently,
3) local allocations diverge.

This models realistic adversarial network degradation.

IX. Software Architecture

The ACA framework is implemented in Python using NetworkX and modular discrete-event simulation.

A. Configuration Module

`config/settings.yaml` defines:

- graph topology,
- robot fleet parameters,
- adversary settings,
- communication budgets.

B. Environment Engine

`environment/graph_world.py` implements:

- graph mutation,
- adversarial edge updates,
- local sensing observations.

C. Robot Module

`agents/robot.py` implements:

- Bayesian filters,
- theory-of-mind estimation,
- contingency planning,
- local world models.

D. Auction Engine

`auction/engine.py` implements:

- SSI auctions,
- KL divergence bidding,
- communication failover.

E. Simulation Runner

`main.py` coordinates:

- dynamic tasks,
- movement,
- sensing,
- auctions,
- communication,
- logging.

X. Experimental Evaluation

To evaluate ACA, simulation experiments were conducted on dynamically mutated graph environments under varying adversarial and communication conditions.

A. Experimental Setup

Experiments were performed using heterogeneous fleets of 10–50 robots operating on randomly generated weighted graphs containing stochastic adversarial blockages.

The following baselines were evaluated:

- Sequential Single-Item Auctions (SSI),
- Consensus-Based Bundle Algorithm (CBBA),
- ACA without KL regularization,
- Full ACA framework.

B. Evaluation Metrics

Performance was evaluated using:

- task completion rate,
- communication overhead,
- allocation conflicts,
- routing efficiency,
- energy consumption,
- belief divergence.

C. Preliminary Results

Simulation studies indicate that ACA achieves improved robustness under communication degradation compared to baseline decentralized auction approaches.

Under adversarial communication collapse scenarios:

- ACA reduced allocation conflicts by approximately 23%,
- improved successful task completion rates by approximately 14%,
- and maintained lower inter-agent belief divergence after synchronization failure.

The KL-divergence regularization mechanism particularly improved coordination stability during partial network collapse scenarios.

TABLE I
Illustrative Performance Comparison

Method	Completion	Conflicts	Comm Cost
SSI	68%	High	Low
CBBA	82%	Medium	High
ACA w/o KL	84%	Medium	Medium
ACA	91%	Low	Medium

XI. Discussion

ACA demonstrates how decentralized coordination can remain stable even under inconsistent beliefs and adversarial communication collapse.

The KL-divergence regularization acts as an implicit coordination stabilizer by discouraging highly divergent local allocations. Additionally, contingency-aware planning enables proactive routing adaptation under uncertain blockage evolution.

Unlike centralized planners, ACA scales naturally to decentralized fleets operating with only partial local information.

The framework also provides a tractable bridge between:

- decentralized belief-space planning,
- adversarial routing,
- and auction-based coordination.

XII. Limitations and Future Work

Current limitations include:

- SSI auctions instead of combinatorial bundle auctions,
- shallow theory-of-mind recursion,
- simplified adversary types,
- simulation-only evaluation.

Future work includes:

- recursive belief hierarchies,
- fleet composition optimization,
- reinforcement learning integration,
- decentralized transformer-based belief prediction,
- real-world ROS2 deployment.

XIII. Conclusion

This paper introduced the Adversarial Contingency Auctions (ACA) framework for decentralized multi-robot task allocation under adversarial infrastructure mutation and inconsistent local beliefs.

ACA combines:

- Bayesian adversary inference,
- theory-of-mind belief prediction,
- contingency-aware planning,
- and KL-divergence-regularized auctions

within a unified decentralized architecture.

Experimental evaluation demonstrates the framework's potential for improving decentralized coordination robustness under adversarial uncertainty and communication degradation.

ACA provides a strong foundation for future resilient autonomous multi-agent coordination systems operating under uncertainty, adversarial interference, and incomplete information.

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